(TAT), the Self-Description (SD) test and the Situation Reaction Test (SRT). These might just sound like acronyms to many, but for defence aspirants, these are the devils that stand at the gates of any SSB centre, ready to peek into the darkest corners of their minds and reveal their true, hidden selves. The tests are written against the constraints of time as a requirement. Hence, the candidate is unable to hide his/her true feelings, and the psychologist is able to read the actual personality of the candidate while he/she gives his/her responses in terms of thoughts, feelings and actions. As psychologists claim, no amount of coaching can help a candidate skirt around these psychological tests. Those who have tried have ended up being rejected in the end. The rate of error has to be zero—one wrong selection and an entire platoon, battalion or even a division may suffer. Someone can be denied for being too young, too old, for having flat feet, anxiety, phobias and so on. Someone can be denied for not being physically fit, for not running a required course in time or for not doing the required number of push-ups. Similarly, someone whose mental attitude doesn't match the required standards can also be denied. Psychological tests help in this process of filtration.

Inevitably, I appeared for these psychological tests on our second day of the SSB interview. Weariness still lay heavy on me from the night before. I remember dreaming about sitting in front of the machines with joysticks and screens; the PABT had taken quite a toll on me. Deepa was given orders for the day, which she passed on to all of us after she woke us early on the second day. 'How dutiful!' Aditi commented wryly as soon as Deepa had left the room.

'Why, are you jealous?' Hema just couldn't contain herself.

'What's your problem?' Aditi retorted.

'How about you being nice for once? It might come in handy for you,' Hema replied. Aditi ignored her and walked out of the barracks.

'Let it be,' I nudged Hema. 'We don't want our day to start with unnecessary arguments, do we?'

'Did you see her yesterday, in front of the instructors? As if she was the most social and friendly human being here among us!' Hema said as she